

2025

MAINSTREAMING GENDER AND ICT ACROSS ASEAN MEMBER STATES

Policy Recommendations





ASEAN Project: Digital Innovation for Women Advancement (DIWA)

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Policy Recommendations



1

Education & Skills Development

Integrate digital literacy into national education systems with gender-sensitive approaches

2

Workplace Inclusion

Implement strong anti-discrimination laws and gender-responsive parental leave policies

3

Entrepreneurship Ecosystem

Establish targeted innovation funds and accessible digital platforms for women entrepreneurs

4

Digital Safety & Inclusion

Develop comprehensive digital rights frameworks addressing gender-based online violence

5

Data Standardization

Harmonize gender-disaggregated ICT data collection across ASEAN member states

From Policy to Implementation:

Move beyond fragmented pilot projects toward scaled, coordinated regional action treating gender integration in ICT as essential, not optional.

Target: USD 1 trillion digital economy by 2030

Approach: Multi-stakeholder partnerships and sustained resource commitments

Measurement: Evidence-based monitoring with standardized indicators



Policy Recommendations

This section offers a series of key policy recommendations that aim to help close the gender digital divide in the ASEAN region. These suggestions build on the issues and insights discussed earlier and are meant to guide governments, private sector groups, and civil society in creating more inclusive digital systems in their communities. Every ASEAN country faces different challenges and works within its own context, so while the recommendations provide a shared framework, they should be flexible and adjusted to fit local needs. The goal is to promote gender equality in digital development across the region, while making sure each country can shape its approach based on its own realities.

1 Education and skills development

Digital Literacy

In today's digital world, girls and women need the right skills to succeed. One of the best ways to make this happen is by teaching digital literacy early on in the national education system. This means starting with basic computer skills and digital know-how in primary and secondary schools. To make it work, two things are needed: first, schools must have proper ICT infrastructure; and second, teachers need to be trained to teach these skills effectively.

Digital Tools and Infrastructure

Before digital skills can be taught well, schools need the right tools. This means having reliable internet, updated computers or tablets, and the basic software needed for learning. In many rural or low-income areas, these resources are still missing. Governments and private partners need to work together to improve digital infrastructure in schools, including regular maintenance and support to keep everything running. Without these basics, even good lesson plans won't be enough. But tech alone isn't the full answer. What really makes a difference is the teacher. Many educators—especially those trained before digital tools became common—may not feel confident using or teaching with them. That's why training teachers is just as important. They need support not only in using digital tools, but in teaching them in ways that are engaging and gender-sensitive. With the right training, teachers can build classrooms where all students, especially girls, feel welcome and ready to grow their digital skills.

Need-Based Support

To close the gender gap in STEM, scholarships and targeted support can help more girls enter these fields. But it's also important to think about how this support is given. Scholarships are often awarded based only on high grades or test scores. While academic achievement matters, this approach can leave out many capable girls who face challenges beyond their control. Research shows that poverty, family duties, poor schooling, and other social pressures can impact how well a student does in school (Aturupane, Glewwe, and Wisniewski 2013; Camacho-Thompson et al. 2016; Simons and Steele 2020). A girl might have real interest and talent in science or tech, but if she's dealing with housework, spotty internet, or mental health issues, her grades might not show her full potential. That's why scholarships should also consider a student's background and circumstances. Support based on both need and potential can help level the playing field and reach the students who need it most.

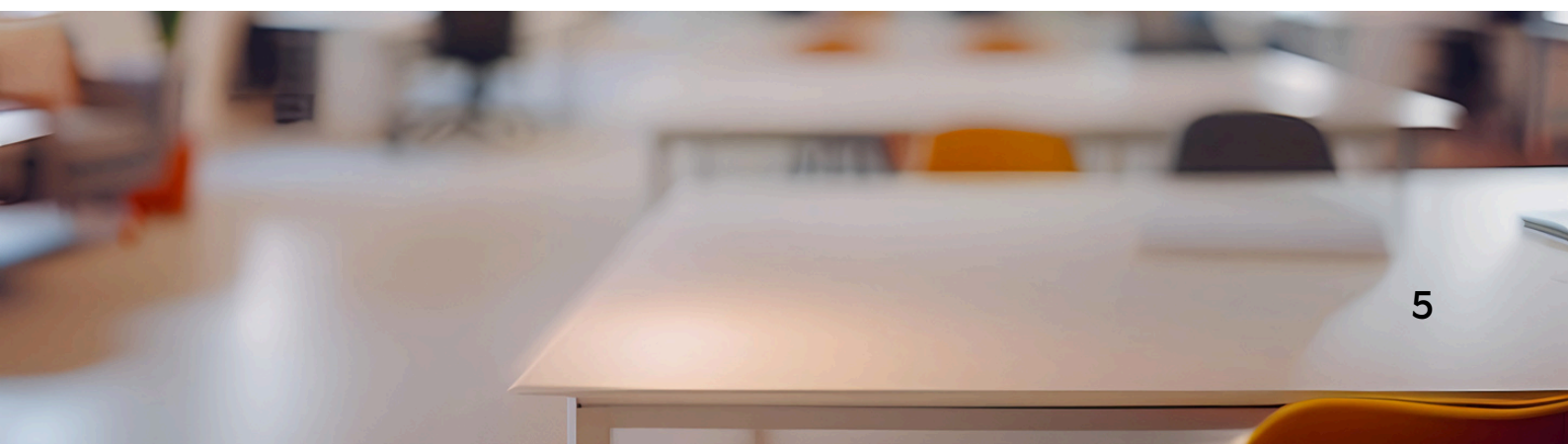
Community-led programs

In places where access to formal education is limited (like geographically isolated and displaced areas) community-based digital literacy programs can help bridge the gap. These programs should be simple, hands-on, and easy to follow, especially for people learning digital skills for the first time. Improving ICT infrastructure is important, but training also needs to connect with everyday life. That means teaching digital tools in ways that match what people already do, like farming, running small businesses, selling goods online, or managing household budgets. For example, in communities with local entrepreneurs, training can focus on using social media or e-commerce platforms to grow their businesses. When lessons feel useful and relevant, people are more likely to keep using technology. It also helps to teach in local languages and use examples people can relate to. Trainings work best when held in familiar, safe places like community centers, women's groups, co-ops, or churches. Involving local leaders can also make a big difference when people see someone they trust using digital tools successfully, they're more likely to give it a try themselves.

2 Workplace inclusion and advancement

Strong Government Mechanisms

Building a more inclusive tech industry in the region isn't just about hiring more women. It's about creating workplaces where they can succeed, grow, and lead. To make that happen, we need a multi-level approach that addresses legal, cultural, and institutional barriers all at once. A good place to start is strong government action. Most ASEAN countries already have anti-discrimination and equal opportunity laws, but how these laws are enforced—and how far they go—varies widely, as shown in Table 2. For real change, these laws need clear implementation plans, regular monitoring, and systems to hold institutions accountable. That means making sure equal pay rules are backed by audits, complaint systems are safe and accessible, and companies get the support they need to meet inclusion goals.



Leave Policies

Governments across the region must also need to rethink how parental leave is given to IT professionals as well. When both mothers and fathers are supported equally, it helps break the idea that caregiving is only a woman's role. This not only makes it easier for women to return to work but also helps shift outdated gender expectations. Figure 16 below shows the gap in paid parental leave between women and men across the ASEAN region, measured in calendar days. The map shows that men generally get much less leave than women. Myanmar gives the longest paid paternity leave at 21 days, while Thailand, Cambodia, and Brunei offer none. In most other ASEAN countries, leave for fathers is only a few days long.

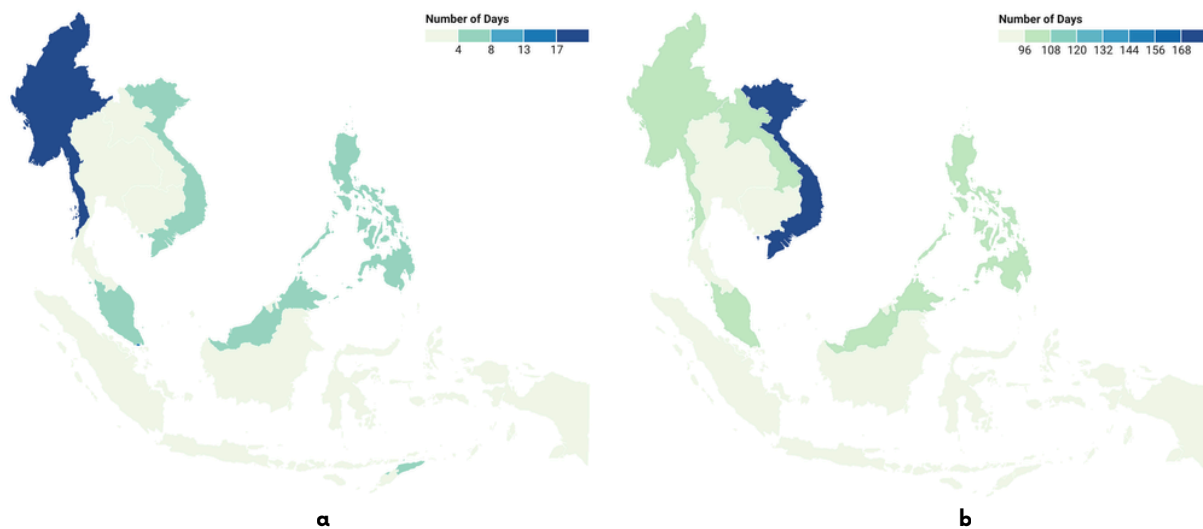


Figure 16. Length of paid parental leave in ASEAN showing (a) paternity leave for men and (b) maternity leave for women, measured in calendar days.

Workplace Safety

Consequently, workplace safety and respect are non-negotiable. In many ICT spaces where men still dominate, strong anti-harassment measures are needed to make sure that all women feel safe, respected, and heard. But these efforts can't stop at basic compliance. Companies need long-term systems in place such as confidential reporting channels, timely investigations, and clear consequences for misconduct. Just as important is building a workplace culture where everyone understands what harassment is and why it matters. Regular training, accountability from leadership, and visible support from management all help shift workplace norms. Without these steps, women may continue to work in environments that are not only unwelcoming, but also harmful to their growth and participation.

3 Entrepreneurship ecosystem building

Targeted Innovation Funds

To build a strong and inclusive entrepreneurship ecosystem for women in the region, equal access to funding, markets, and training must be a priority. Many women still face barriers when starting or growing a business, especially in male-dominated fields like tech. Access to capital remains one of the biggest challenges, with women entrepreneurs often receiving less support than men. One way to address this is through innovation funds designed for women-led startups. These can offer grants, low-interest loans, or equity investments tailored to women's needs. But financing alone is not enough. Many women-owned businesses also struggle to reach bigger markets due to limited networks or visibility. Trade fairs, exhibitions, and online marketplaces can help connect them with new customers and business partners.

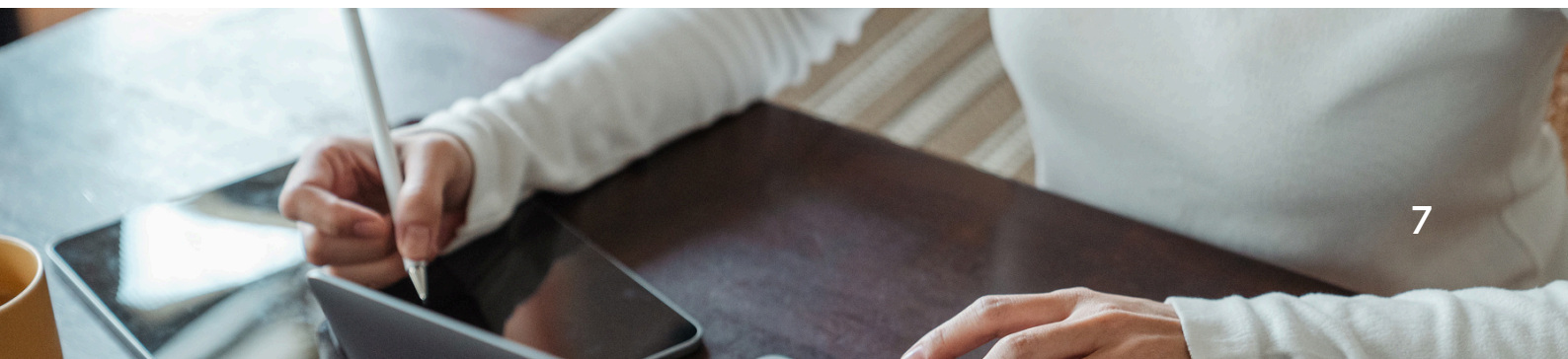
ASEAN could take a big step by launching a regional innovation fund focused on women-led digital startups. This wouldn't just provide capital. It would also promote collaboration across all countries in the region. The fund could support startups at different stages of growth, helping them scale and compete across the region. It could also create opportunities for knowledge sharing and allow successful business models to be adapted in other countries. Most importantly, it would give women from different ASEAN nations a chance to work together on shared challenges. A regional approach like this ensures that women entrepreneurs, no matter where they come from, have a fair chance to succeed.

Accessible Digital Platforms

E-commerce platforms are an important tool for women entrepreneurs and informal workers alike who want to reach more customers as possible. But many women still face barriers like limited digital skills or poor internet access. To address this, government and private sector efforts should focus on building e-commerce programs that are simple, inclusive, and easy to use. These platforms should guide users through setting up online stores, listing products, and using secure digital payments. Training should cover both basic digital skills and practical strategies like online marketing. It's also important to improve logistics so that women in remote areas can take part in online selling. Support in local languages and mobile-friendly tools will help make these platforms more accessible to more women.

Public Awareness Campaigns

Societal norms and biases still hold many women back from fully pursuing entrepreneurship. Cultural expectations often confine women to domestic roles, making them less likely to take business risks later on. Gender stereotypes can also lower their confidence and limit their chances. To change this, public campaigns should challenge these outdated ideas and promote real examples of successful women entrepreneurs. Schools should teach both entrepreneurship and gender equality early on. The media can also help by showing more stories of women succeeding in business. Supporting inclusive entrepreneurship should be seen not just as a women's concern, but as a key part of social and economic progress.



4. Digital safety and inclusion

Digital Rights Frameworks

Strategies to address cybercrime and online harassment need to consider gender-specific risks and impacts, both at the national and regional level. Women face specific threats like stalking, doxxing, and sexual harassment that require clear and pro-active legal recognition. Laws should define online gender-based violence and set strong penalties to hold offenders accountable. Without proper legal frameworks, many cases go unreported or unresolved. Governments should also fund awareness campaigns that inform women of their digital rights and how to protect themselves online. These campaigns need to be accessible, using different languages and formats. When women know their rights and the risks, they're more confident navigating digital spaces and taking action when needed.

Integrated Support

It is also important to link digital safety services with the support systems already in place for gender-based violence. Victims of online abuse shouldn't have to go through a completely separate process just to get help. Bringing services together makes it easier for them to access counseling, legal aid, and reporting tools in one place. For example, shelters for survivors could include digital safety sessions and provide safe internet access. Legal services should help victims file complaints and understand their rights online. Counselors also need training to deal with the emotional effects of cyberbullying and exploitation. At the same time, police and legal offices should have clear steps for handling online threats and digital evidence. Support should be trauma-informed and respect what the victim is ready for. Online abuse often goes hand-in-hand with offline violence, so joined-up services are key.

Collaboration

Tech companies play a major role in creating a safe online environment. They must build tools that allow users to report abuse easily and get timely help. These tools should be visible, user-friendly, and available in multiple languages. Content moderation must be thorough and consistent to ensure harmful content is removed quickly. Platforms should be transparent about how they handle reports and what actions are taken. Audits and updates can help improve systems over time. Collaborating with women's rights groups can help companies understand the impact of online abuse. Digital platforms should also publish safety reports to show what progress is being made. Offering safety settings like content filters and account protections by default can reduce unwanted risk.



5. Data standardization and monitoring

Data Accuracy

To achieve the first four points discussed in this section, however, there should be a strong foundation built on consistent, reliable, and gender-sensitive data practices. Without accurate data, it is nearly impossible to measure gaps, evaluate progress, or understand where interventions are most needed. Governments, including both public and private institutions, must agree on what to measure, how to measure it, and how often to report it. For example, if one country in the ASEAN region defines "ICT employment" differently than another, then comparing women's participation in that sector becomes meaningless at all. Some countries have their own reporting mechanisms, which may align poorly with international frameworks. This patchwork of practices in the region creates confusion among member states and hinders regional collaboration, making it hard to draw accurate comparisons or identify shared challenges. To avoid this, countries in the ASEAN region must harmonize their definitions on gender and ICT, while synchronizing their reporting cycles at the same time. This effort can be supported by adopting international standards, such as those provided by the ITU or the World Bank's Gender Data Portal, which offer clear guidelines for classifying and collecting gender data.

Data Standardization

However, standardizing indicators is just the beginning. Monitoring progress also means ensuring that the data is updated regularly. In this way, these indicators can better reflect current realities, especially as technology and usage patterns evolve rapidly. What may have been relevant five years ago, such as basic mobile phone usage, may now be insufficient especially in a world dominated by digital platforms, e-commerce, and AI-powered services. Moreover, regular monitoring and evaluation can help flag emerging disparities in these indicators early, such as new forms of exclusion based on digital literacy or cybersecurity concerns disproportionately affecting women. To do this however, national statistical offices must be equipped with the tools needed to gather, analyze, and publish gender-disaggregated ICT data more effectively. Using mapping tools and, where appropriate, remote sensing technologies, can also enhance data accuracy and offer spatial insights into gendered ICT access and infrastructure availability. It can also help policymakers pinpoint where investments in digital infrastructure, literacy training, or safety initiatives might be most needed for women and girls.

Trainings on Data and Inclusivity

It is also important to recognize at this point that good data starts with trained people and smart tools at the national statistical office. Training staff to collect and analyze sex-disaggregated data helps prevent mistakes and ensures reliability. But this training must go beyond technical skills. For one, it also needs to cover the fundamentals of gender itself. Many staff members, especially those without a background in social sciences, may not fully understand what gender means in a statistical or policy context. Gender is not just about biological differences between men and women; it refers to the roles, behaviors, expectations, and opportunities that societies assign to people based on their perceived sex. These roles can deeply influence who has access to technology, who gets trained, who gets hired, and who benefits from digital tools. Without understanding these important concepts, data collectors might overlook critical questions or misclassify responses, which skews results and undermines policymaking.

Data Collaboratives

The community can also play its part in filling out the data gaps in gender and ICT. Local organizations, civil society groups, educators, and even tech users themselves have valuable insights into the digital realities women face in their everyday lives. These groups often operate at the grassroots level and can see patterns and challenges that national-level surveys miss. For example, they might notice that women are less likely to attend digital skills workshops due to unpaid care work or safety concerns. Community-based organizations can help identify these barriers and ensure they are reflected in the data. Importantly, data collection efforts should not be limited to formal surveys or bureaucratic channels. There should be a space for participatory methods where women and marginalized groups can voice out their own experiences. Making these processes free, simple, and accessible helps build trust and encourages broader participation in the community. When people feel that their input matters, they are more likely to share honestly and regularly, which strengthens the quality and relevance of the overall data.



Policy Recommendations

Strategic Framework for Gender-Inclusive ICT Development



Education & Skills

Digital literacy
integration & gender-
sensitive curricula



Workplace Inclusion

Anti-discrimination
laws & family-friendly
policies



Entrepreneurship

Innovation funds
& accessible
platforms



Digital Safety

Innovation funds
& accessible
platforms



Data Standards

Harmonized monitoring
& evidence-based
decisions

I. Education & Skills Development

Digital Literacy Integration

Integrate digital literacy into national education systems from primary through tertiary levels with gender-sensitive approaches.

Infrastructure Investment:

Ensure all classrooms have reliable internet, updated devices, and essential software with maintenance support

Teacher Training:

Provide comprehensive professional development in digital tools and gender-sensitive pedagogy

Need-Based Support Systems

Establish scholarships and targeted support combining merit and need-based criteria to reach talented girls facing barriers.

Holistic Assessment:

Consider economic hardship, family responsibilities, and systemic barriers alongside academic performance

Wraparound Services:

Provide mentorship, career counseling, and practical support beyond financial assistance

Community-Led Programs

Develop community-based digital literacy programs in areas where formal education is limited, emphasizing practical applications.

Local Language Delivery:

Use familiar languages and culturally relevant examples in safe community spaces

Practical Focus:

Connect digital skills to daily activities like farming, business, or household management

II. Workplace Inclusion & Advancement

Strong Legal Frameworks

Implement and enforce comprehensive anti-discrimination and equal opportunity legislation with clear accountability mechanisms.

Equal Pay Enforcement:

Conduct regular audits, transparent reporting, and accessible complaint procedures

Implementation Support:

Provide guidance and resources to help companies meet inclusion standards

Progressive Leave Policies

Reform parental leave policies to support both mothers and fathers equally, challenging traditional gender norms.

Balanced Allocation:

Provide substantial paid leave for both parents to share caregiving responsibilities

Workplace Flexibility:

Support remote work, flexible hours, and family-friendly workplace policies

Workplace Safety Standards

Establish and enforce zero-tolerance policies for harassment with confidential reporting and swift response mechanisms.

Prevention Training:

Regular education on respectful workplace behavior and unconscious bias for all employees

Leadership Accountability:

Hold management responsible for creating and maintaining inclusive work environments

III. Entrepreneurship Ecosystem Building

Targeted Innovation Funds

Establish dedicated funding mechanisms specifically designed to support women-led digital startups and businesses.

Regional Innovation Fund:

Launch ASEAN-wide fund supporting women-led digital startups with cross-border collaboration incentives

Alternative Collateral:

Reform lending requirements to accept non-traditional forms of credit security for women entrepreneurs

Accessible Digital Platforms

Create user-friendly e-commerce and digital business platforms with comprehensive support for women entrepreneurs.

Platform Integration:

Provide training on online store setup, digital payments, and marketing strategies

Rural Connectivity:

Ensure logistics and delivery support for women entrepreneurs in remote areas

Public Awareness Campaigns

Challenge societal norms and promote positive role models to encourage women's entrepreneurship participation.

Media Representation:

Showcase successful women entrepreneurs and challenge limiting gender stereotypes

Early Education:

Include entrepreneurship and gender equality in school curricula from elementary levels

IV. Digital Safety & Inclusion

Digital Rights Frameworks

Develop comprehensive legal frameworks that specifically address gender-based online violence and digital rights.

Legal Definition:

Clearly define online gender-based violence with specific penalties and enforcement mechanisms

Digital Rights Education:

Fund awareness campaigns teaching women about digital rights and safety strategies

Integrated Support Systems

Connect digital safety services with existing gender-based violence support infrastructure for comprehensive assistance.

One-Stop Services:

Provide counseling, legal aid, and digital safety support in unified locations

Training Integration:

Train existing GBV counselors and legal advocates in digital safety and cyber evidence handling

Platform Collaboration

Establish mandatory partnerships with technology companies to create safer online environments for women.

Reporting Tools:

Require user-friendly, multilingual abuse reporting with transparent response timelines

Safety by Design:

Mandate privacy settings, content filters, and account protection features as platform defaults

V. Data Standardization & Monitoring

Harmonized Data Standards

Establish common definitions and reporting frameworks for gender-disaggregated ICT data across ASEAN member states.

Common Definitions:

Adopt ITU and World Bank standards for ICT employment and digital inclusion indicators

Synchronized Reporting:

Coordinate data collection cycles and methodology across national statistical offices

Capacity Building Programs

Train national statistical office staff in gender-sensitive data collection, analysis, and interpretation methods.

Technical Training:

Provide comprehensive education on gender concepts, intersectionality, and statistical best practices

Technology Tools:

Support adoption of mapping tools, remote sensing, and digital data collection platforms

Community Data Partnerships

Engage local organizations and communities in participatory data collection to capture lived experiences.

Participatory Methods:

Use community surveys, focus groups, and digital storytelling to complement official statistics

Accessible Processes:

Ensure data collection is free, simple, and builds trust with marginalized communities

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